

TROUBLES MOUNT
Bhupesh Baghel outside his Bhilai home, March 26

PTI

CHHATTISGARH

STORM AT BAGHEL'S DOOR

By Rahul Noronha

Former Chhattisgarh chief minister and Congress leader Bhupesh Baghel finds himself in the eye of a political storm, as two central agencies target him with investigations that have set Chhattisgarh's political temperature rising—despite elections still being far off.

First, on March 10, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) commenced searches at his premises in Durg, where Baghel and his son Chaitanya live, as well as at 13 other locations across the state. The searches were related to a case concerning what is known as the 'liquor scam'. The operation concluded later in the evening, with the ED not officially disclosing its findings. However, the visuals of ED staff bringing in a currency note-counting machine in the afternoon, followed by Baghel loyalists pelting stones at ED personnel as they exited the premises, added to the drama.

A little more than two weeks later, on March 26, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) came knocking in connection with its probe into the Mahadev betting scam. A total of 60 locations across Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Delhi and West Bengal were searched, in addition to the premises of three IPS officers—Anand Chhabra, Abhishek Pallav and Arif Sheikh—and Baghel's two former OSDs (officers on special duty), including Saumya Chaurasia.

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Both probes have been proceeding at the usual pace for years, so why is the heat being turned up on Baghel now? Various theories are circulating about the timing, with some linking them to the upcoming Bihar polls. Baghel hails from the Kurmi community, which has a sizeable vote base in Bihar and is also the community to which Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar belongs.

What is the liquor scam, and what does the ED have on it so far? Similarly, what is the Mahadev betting racket, and why is the CBI investigating it? The ED claims that between 2019 and 2023, as much as Rs 2,161 crore was siphoned off through the sale of liquor, evading the payment of excise. To date, the ED has charged former IAS officer Anil Tuteja, legislator Lakhma, Indian Telecom Service officer Arun Pati Tripathi and Anwar Dhebar—brother of former Raipur mayor and Congress leader Aijaz Dhebar—among others. Lakhma, an MLA from the Bastar region, was arrested in January and is in jail, as are Anwar and Tuteja. The ED claims Lakhma received Rs 72 crore from the proceeds of the scam, which